One of the magazines involved, however, justified its actions stating that the conversation ‘is more than evidence of the fact that she [Radia] had a personal and direct equation with him [Ratan]’. But this begged the question how it had the right to publish the conversation when the very stated reason, without other buttressing evidence, cast upon them a duty to withhold its dissemination. This is so, as no one’s ‘personal and direct equation’ with anyone but a criminal, would attract public interest. The publication was, therefore, unjustifiable, wrong and violative of individual rights.

In reality, as *The Wall Street Journal* reported, ‘When the “2G” telecom scandal erupted … India’s Tata Group quickly became the poster child for allegations of corruption in the government’s sale of mobile phone spectrum in 2008.’ The attendant circumstances revealed that the Tata Group was targeted by vested interests. It was evident when two petitioners insisted on getting Ratan and Radia’s names in the list of the accused during the hearing of the 2G matter by the special court. And the two, surprisingly, turned out to be the unlikeliest of petitioners—one of them was a journalist and the other, interestingly, a ‘Ghaziabad-based scrap dealer’. The identity of the petitioners persuaded many to conclude that they were a front for some corporate house.

In view of their insistence, the judge directed the CBI to investigate the matter. After an inquiry the agency concluded that the Tatas had not received any extra benefit. On the basis of this report, the special court judge dismissed the application to include Ratan and some others in the list of the accused and imposed a fine of Rs 10,000 on each of the petitioners on the ground that the ‘complaints were not only devoid of any substance but are also contrary to law’. This was not reported prominently in the mainstream news, adding credence to Ratan’s claim that some powerful corporate entities with the help of a section of media were targeting the Tata Group.

The special court’s decision was a shot in the arm for the group. At the end of the day, multiple agencies vouched for the fact that neither had Ratan manipulated the 2G spectrum allocations, nor did the group benefit in any way from its advocacy. Most importantly, the PAC heaped praise on Ratan for his honesty and integrity. Speaking at a press conference after the committee meeting, Murli Manohar Joshi said that the ‘industrialist [Ratan] was candid and straightforward’.